

PTI

MADHYA PRADESH JODO
Kamal Nath used the yatra itinerary to firm up the Congress's standing

MADHYA PRADESH

WALKING THE BHOPAL TALK

By Rahul Noronha

The Madhya Pradesh leg of the Bharat Jodo Yatra has offered the local Congress a chance to prep up for the next assembly election. November 2023 is still a year away, but state Congress chief and former chief minister Kamal Nath wants to use the yatra's momentum to the party's advantage. In a 12-day itinerary, the yatra route maps out 17 assembly segments in six districts in the state's Malwa and Nimar regions. Barring the tribal-dominated seats here, where the Congress is still strong, both are considered BJP strongholds. In 2018, the Congress had improved its tally here though, mopping up 34 of 66 seats in the Indore and Ujjain divisions (both in Malwa)—a crucial contributor to its victory. A good chance then to try and put some sheen back into its image. That Priyanka Gandhi joined her brother Rahul for the first time as the yatra entered MP on November 23, at Bodarli village in Burhanpur district, could not have harmed that cause.

One of the avowed objectives of the yatra, as stated by Rahul Gandhi, is to stand against "hatred, violence and fear". The party got an opportunity to set that in a real context as the yatra passed through Khargone—the town had witnessed communal riots in April. A controversy broke out on November 25, as a video surfaced with a pro-Pakistan slogan being allegedly heard in it during the Khargone leg. Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan promptly raked it up, while the Congress accused the BJP of putting out a "doctored video".

THE YATRA'S PRIME FOCUS WAS ON TRIBAL VOTERS, WHO HAD MOSTLY BACKED CONGRESS IN 2018

But a good part of the focus was on tribals. After Adivasi communities supported the Congress nearly universally in 2018, they have become a focus group for the BJP and it is trying to woo them with a combination of symbolism and concrete policy—not the least of which is the implementation of PESA (Provision of the Panchayats) Rules in scheduled areas, which had been pending for 26 years. So the Congress has been presenting itself as the tribals' "original friend", with Rahul repeating his recent criticism of PM Narendra Modi for calling them vanvasis. On November 24, during a visit to the Khandwa home of tribal icon Tantiya Bheel—who had fought the British in the 19th century—he accused the RSS of "supporting the British". Incidentally, Tantiya is one among many tribal heroes the BJP has named as being ignored by previous Congress governments. To counter any Congress gains among tribal communities, the BJP has announced a yatra of its own: the PESA Jagrukta (Awareness) Yatra.

There was another positive spinoff to be hoped for: addressing infighting in the state Congress. Kamal Nath appointed independent MLA Surendra Singh to take care of the Burhanpur leg of the yatra and his arch-rival, Congress's Arun Yadav, for Khargone. Rahul's presence is expected to smoothen out differences among leaders. "The presence of Rahulji and Priyankaji will galvanise party workers. The long-standing association of the Congress with tribal communities will be reinforced. And the yatra will nullify the effect of the divisive politics practised by BJP," says Kamal Nath.

The rest of it was taken up with checking other boxes: a Narmada *aarti* at Omkareshwar, the Mahakal temple, a historical gurudwara and the Dargah-e-Hakimi, a religious site of the Dawoodi Bohra community, in Burhanpur, and the birthplace of B.R. Ambedkar at Mhow. ■